impregnable BJP fortification—and one vacated by the party's new national president Nitin Nabin—Kishor had scripted a fairytale victory. The JSP chief won the Bankipur assembly byelection decisively, defeating the BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha by some 19,324 votes. The RJD's Rekha Kumari trailed so far behind that she lost her security deposit.

The result, coming just nine months after the BJP-led NDA swept the November 2025 assembly poll, arrives as an early setback for CM Choudhary, who was facing his first election after taking over from Nitish Kumar in April. For the JSP, it provided the breakthrough it has been desperate for since the humiliating whitewash in the assembly poll. Most importantly, it makes the 49-year-old PK not just India's most celebrated election strategist but also now a politician who can legitimately claim to have translated strategy into votes.



"THE BJP'S 30-YEAR-OLD FORTRESS COLLAPSED IN JUST 30 DAYS. BIHAR HAS GIVEN THE PARTY A MASSIVE MANDATE, THEY MUST UNDERSTAND THE MESSAGE SENT BY THE PEOPLE..."

PRASHANT KISHOR, *Founder & President, Jan Suraaj Party; Bankipur MLA*

A STRONGHOLD BREACHED

For Bihar and the BJP, the symbolism is impossible to ignore. Even before the saffron party had become a contender in Bihar, Bankipur had been its 'fortress'. The party had been winning here since 1995; nine consecutive election wins had made the urban Patna constituency one of the party's most dependable seats. The bypoll was necessitated by the elevation of Nabin, a five-time MLA from the seat, to the Rajya Sabha. So, this was a contest the ruling party was expecting to sail through.

When a party fails to retain the seat of its national president, questions inevitably arise about organisational discipline, candidate selection and political management. Apart from all that, the defeat also now lends fresh credence to PK's long-standing argument that a significant section of Bihar's electorate votes for the NDA less out of ideological conviction than to prevent the RJD from returning to power. Bankipur suggests that when voters perceive a credible third alternative, the tactical support can become fluid. The fact that the BJP deployed virtually its entire political machinery—some 200 leaders, including CM Choudhary, several cabinet ministers, Nabin himself, and star campaigners such as Bhojpuri actor-netas Manoj Tiwari and Pawan Singh—and still failed to retain the seat makes the theory all the more consequential.

The win did not come easy for PK. The BJP used all the resources at its disposal to derail his campaign. Just days after the JSP chief filed his nomination, the BJP moved swiftly on July 15 to induct three of the party's 2025 assembly poll candidates from Patna district along with several other party functionaries. The timing was deliberate, designed to create an impression that Kishor's fledgling party was unravelling and leaders were deserting him. In the event, the move counted for little.

For Kishor, the victory represents something more profound. For nearly two years now, critics had been dismissive of his party. In the 2025 assembly poll, the year-old JSP, which he had painstakingly built walking thousands of kilometres across Bihar, failed to win a single assembly seat. The party ended up with 3.4 per cent of the popular vote; only two of its 238 candidates could save their deposits. Many wondered whether his political appeal existed only for TV studios and campaign war rooms. Bankipur has silenced the doubters emphatically.

Several factors explain why Kishor prevailed. The first is credibility. Rather than making extravagant promises, he campaigned on the promise of integrity, accountability and seriousness in public life. That message resonated with an urban electorate weary of conventional political rhetoric. Then there was the concentrated, door-to-door campaign—PK himself commented later that "the BJP's 30-year-old fortress collapsed in just 30 days".

After the results, PK had also declared, "This election is not being fought over Bankipur's drains and lanes. It is about who should lead Bihar. If the BJP wants another

WHAT CHANGED IN 9 MONTHS

Nitin Nabin had won Bankipur by over 51,000 votes in Nov. '25

- **PK's winning coalition:** Intense 30-day direct outreach poll campaign united two unlikely voter blocs—anti-BJP voters who saw Jan Suraaj as the strongest challenger, and the disillusioned traditional NDA supporters
- **Nitish goes missing:** Since stepping down, Nitish Kumar has largely remained in the background, leaving new CM Samrat Choudhary to carry the NDA's political burden
- **Samrat fails test:** Bankipur was the first election under the new CM's watch, exposed the fact that he has not inherited the goodwill and credibility Nitish had built
- **Disgruntled voters:** Graft allegations, student protests